independent political activity or organised initiatives such as unions, student and ethnic groups, regional associations or political parties as they were seen as potential destabilisers of power and were thus systematically repressed. On the other hand, the war against the colony, and later on years of civil war, left a feeling of aversion to conflicts which, in the opinion of most interviewees, led to avoidance of confrontation and the promotion of public debates and discussions. All the interviewees questioned the possibility of constructing democratic processes even though the country can now rely on formal institutions, such as elections, parties and a parliament.

However, both countries reveal fundamental differences. One of the most relevant is the way the state intervenes in the economy to organise and plan the economic processes and development. In Angola, we experienced an ever-present and highly bureaucratic state which is the main employer in the country, mainly in the oil sector and the swollen bureaucracy. The state is in charge of the enforcement and control of the streets, the investment management (with control over the companies established in the country and the selection of the priority sectors for investment), and is at the centre of civil society (through community-based organisations affiliated to the party in government, for women, the young and rural people). In many cases, the government is represented at company boards which, according to the interviewees, equates to the possibility of receiving 'commissions' or bribes in each accomplished, authorised or rendered investment.[19] The interviewees also confirmed the impression that the Angolan government is highly capable of intervening and organising the economy in spite of its low level of transparency and social participation in decision-making processes.

In Mozambique, the interviews revealed the ambiguous role of the state. On the one hand, the interviewees stressed its capacity for coercion, repressive actions against protests and uprisings of the population and workers, and control over civil society's critical stances.[20] Nevertheless, many relativised the state's power to lead the ongoing economic process in the country and negotiate and impose conditions on foreign investments. As a hostage of public debt, the Mozambican state was repeatedly associated with a so-called 'incapacity' to attract, control and monitor investments in its territory, particularly concerning labour and environmental issues and community rights. The result of the equation is a state with a seemingly relative fragility in the face of huge multinational corporations and the required flow of resources from cooperation and donations to have the national accounts settled, but present enough in the control of society, communities and workers. This fragility is highlighted by the recent discoveries